‘Of this vast tract of country,’ Bernier writes, ‘a large portion is extremely fertile; the large kingdom of Bengale, for instance, surpassing Egypt itself, not only in the production of rice, corn, and other necessaries of life, but of innumerable articles of commerce which are not cultivated in Egypt; such as silks, cotton, and indigo.’ Artisans manufacture ‘carpets, brocades, embroideries, gold and silver cloths, and the various sorts of silk and cotton goods, which are used in the country or exported abroad’.

The king is the proprietor of all land in the kingdom, writes Bernier (Megasthenes also noted this in Mauryan times). He asks ‘whether it would not be more advantageous for the King as well as for the people, if the former ceased to be sole possessor of the land, and the right of private property were recognised in the Indies as it is with us? I have carefully compared the condition of European states, where that right is acknowledged, with the condition of those countries where it is not known, and am persuaded that the absence of it among the people is injurious to the best interests of the Sovereign himself’. Lack of formal property rights, argues Bernier, deters people from investing in their lands and homes to improve their lot, since they may lose them based on the whims of power. This, in turn, depresses tax revenues and encourages people to hide their surpluses in gold. (In his day, expanding property rights and waning feudalism had in recent centuries put Europe on a heady new path of economic and cultural evolution.)

Provincial governors and tax collectors, writes Bernier, ‘have an authority almost absolute over the peasantry, and nearly as much over the artisans and merchants of the towns and villages within their district; and nothing can be imagined more cruel and oppressive than the manner in which it is exercised’. Therefore, if and ‘when wealth is acquired [by a commoner], the possessor, so far from living with increased comfort and assuming an air of independence, studies the means by which he may appear indigent: his dress, lodging, and furniture continue to be mean, and he is careful, above all things, never to indulge in the pleasures of the table. In the meantime, his gold and silver remain buried at a great depth in the ground’.

This ‘miserable system of government’, mixing despotic power with lack of private property, went beyond the Mughal realm and was said to be pan-Asian. What Bernier refers to was an Indian system of non-hereditary